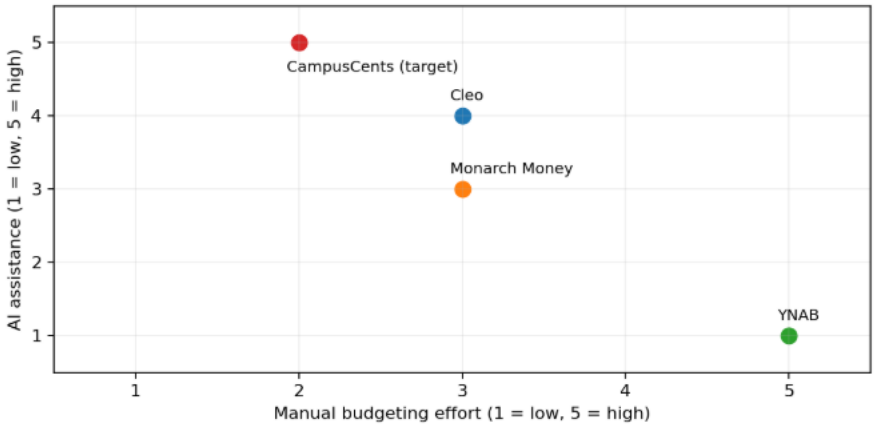
CampusCents Competitive Landscape

Competitor Map

The competitor map compares CampusCents with Cleo, Monarch Money, and YNAB based on two factors, manual budgeting effort and AI assistance. Each competitor was assigned an estimated score from 1 to 5 using findings from the interviews and competitor teardowns. Cleo provides strong AI assistance through its chatbot but requires users to interact with it for certain tasks. Monarch Money offers financial tracking and AI features but still requires some manual budgeting effort. YNAB relies heavily on manual budgeting with limited AI assistance. CampusCents is positioned as a proposed solution that aims to reduce manual effort while providing stronger AI-driven financial recommendations.



Competitor Comparison Table

The competitor comparison table identifies the strengths and weaknesses of each application and highlights opportunities for CampusCents.

Competitor	Strengths	Weaknesses / Research Findings	CampusCents Opportunity
Cleo	Conversational AI, engaging chatbot, automated savings	Chat interface requires too many steps for quick spending decisions	Safe-to-Spend dashboard widget
Monarch Money	Comprehensive financial tracking, detailed dashboards, AI assistance	Interview participant wanted more proactive mid-month budgeting guidance	AI Mid-Month Auto-Balancer

YNAB	Structured zero-based budgeting, spending awareness, financial discipline	Manual categorization and maintenance can overwhelm users	Smart Auto-Categorization
CampusCents (Proposed)	Student-focused budgeting, AI recommendations, simplified financial management	Features still require implementation and validation	Combine automation, simplicity, and proactive financial guidance

The comparison reveals that each competitor approaches financial management differently. Cleo focuses on conversational AI and automated savings, Monarch Money emphasizes comprehensive financial tracking, and YNAB promotes structured budgeting habits. The interview findings suggest opportunities to improve convenience, reduce manual effort, and provide more timely financial guidance. CampusCents could combine these advantages into a simpler experience designed for college students. Rather than replacing existing budgeting methods entirely, the goal is to make financial information easier to understand and act upon.

Ranked Switching Triggers

The ranked switching triggers identify the main reasons users might consider switching from their current budgeting applications to CampusCents.

Rank	Switching Trigger	Supporting Evidence	CampusCents Response
1	Excessive manual budgeting work	YNAB participant stopped using the app because maintaining transactions became overwhelming (LOG-03)	Smart Auto-Categorization
2	Financial guidance arrives too late	Monarch Money participant wanted recommendations before overspending occurred (LOG-02)	AI Mid-Month Auto-Balancer
3	Too many steps to check spending	Cleo participant found chatbot interactions inconvenient for quick	Safe-to-Spend widget

		spending decisions (LOG-01)	
4	Declining engagement with budgeting tools	Cleo participant reported that chatbot novelty faded over time (LOG-01)	Quick, actionable financial insights

The switching triggers were ranked based on the severity of the problems described in the interview findings and their potential impact on continued app usage. Excessive manual budgeting work received the highest priority because the YNAB participant reported abandoning the application due to its complexity. Delayed financial guidance ranked second because it limits users' ability to correct spending habits before exceeding their budgets. Inconvenient access to spending information ranked third, followed by declining engagement with budgeting tools.